# Sierra City, California: Using Real-Time Data to Stay Ahead of Fire Weather

Tucked into the Sierra Nevada mountains, Sierra City is the kind of place where everyone knows one another. Fewer than 300 people call it home, and nearly 70% are over the age of 65. There's only one main road in or out, cell service is spotty at best, and a wildfire threat here can quickly become a dangerous situation. In a place where evacuation can be slow and communications unreliable, early warnings are critical.

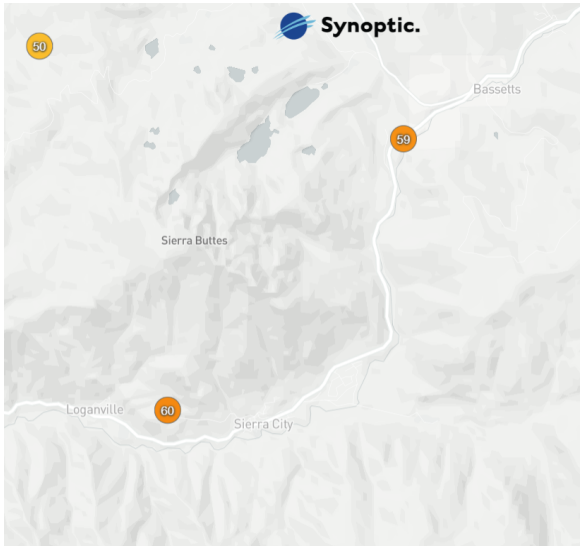
### Taking Action and Finding the Right Data Source

Concerned about their neighbors' safety, a group of local activists came together to build a fire weather monitoring program tailored to Sierra City's needs. Their goal: to give people as much time as possible to prepare, act, and, if necessary, get out safely.

These activists found Synoptic Data while searching for reliable, real-time environmental data in their area. Through the platform, they identified local weather stations and connected with Synoptic to request access to the data through their Open Access program. The Open Access program provides access to publicly available weather and environmental data through Synoptic's Weather API. It is mainly available for students, but it also serves other applications, such as outdoor hobbyists or local safety operations. The program was a good fit for the Sierra City community, allowing them the ability to continuously monitor local real-time weather conditions.

### Communications in a Rural Community

The activist group built a custom software application using Synoptic's Weather API. When wind speed, temperature, humidity, or other monitored parameters cross pre-set thresholds, the system automatically alerts more than 100 residents via email. In more serious situations, they turn to tried-and-true tools: local radio communications to spread the word quickly, and, when necessary, sirens, although those aren't always trusted to work every time.




No one is ordered to evacuate. Instead, the information is there so people can make their own decisions with enough lead time to take action. For Sierra City, where the "evacuation plan" is essentially getting on the highway and joining a slow-moving line of cars, that time can make all the difference.

"Evacuation is straightforward," one organizer said. "You get on the highway, you get in line, and you leave

until it’s safe. The challenge is knowing when it’s time to start. If we can give folks an extra hour to pack up and get ready, that could save lives.”

**Empowering Residents and Saving Lives**

Thanks to the dedication of local volunteers, and the power of real-time data, Sierra City is better prepared for fire weather, helping protect one another in a place where community truly comes first.

Residents can monitor current conditions and sign up for alerts at: [Sierra City Fire Risk Dashboard]

